overestimate the government's understanding of the business. More often than not, this becomes a political football. As the number of workers are larger, either the government refuses permission or keeps the matter pending for ages.

Besides amending labour laws taking more realities on board, it is also necessary for the government to stop being the arbiter between industry and labour. The crux of the relationship between the employer and labour should be left to be determined by the two concerned parties. Aspects of safety and working conditions should be left to expert supervisory bodies. If there are contractual disputes, the courts can adjudicate.

The Right Policies to Be Truly Self-Reliant

Dependence on the world for food was a deep concern for India in the 1950s and 1960s. This is no longer the case.

Imports of pulses and edible oils cost India $11.1 billion in 2019–20. Exports of rice, cereal preparations, other cereals and edible oilseeds fetched $9.4 billion. On cereal, pulses and edible oil, India had a trade deficit of $1.7 billion. On the overall food front, India had a larger surplus of over $16 billion.

Should India go for becoming atmanirbhar in edible oils and pulses where it is significantly dependent on imports? On edible oils, the trade deficit exceeded $8.4 billion, quite a sizeable amount. On pulses, our deficit was $1.4 billion.

If India decides to be atmanirbhar in edible oils and pulses, it will require the country to shift a considerable amount of agricultural land from other crops to production of edible oils and pulses. India's net sown area of 140 million hectares is occupied by some crop or the other. There is no real vacant land. If you shift land from existing crops, it might lead to substitution of rice, wheat or maize and might also lead to reduction in exports of these commodities. If the value of the edible oil and pulses crop